CASE STUDY

Hope Turns Sawdust

A native of Gaya, Bihar, Pankaj did not want to be a carpenter like his father, Arjun. He studied for a BA degree and followed it up with a two-year fitter course at the Industrial Training Institute (ITI) in his hometown. He served as an apprentice at an auto firm for a year, but a permanent job remained a dream. After doing odd jobs for the next year while hunting for office work, he got an offer from a Gurugram firm, but the salary was just Rs 12,000 a month. Meanwhile, he got married and had a household to run. So, Pankaj settled for a job at a plywood shop in Kirti Nagar's furniture market, making laminate catalogues. While he may have regrets, his father Arjun is very proud: "He is earning double of what the office was offering and getting bonus and Provident Fund too." ***—Sonal Khetarpal***



ARUN KUMAR

Pankaj Kumar, 28, Delhi

Works in a plywood shop

Monthly income: Rs 24,000

Education: BA, Fitter course in ITI, Gaya

MISMATCH 4

ASPIRATION VS JOB REALITY

Often, the workforce shortage is not simply a question of availability but also of interest and social perception. Take hospitality and tourism. It is a sector with relatively low entry barriers and is expected to require 1.4 million additional workers by 2031, according to Quess estimates, creating a manpower deficit of 946,543 as rising disposable incomes and domestic tourism drive demand. Yet the biggest gaps are at the operational and supervisory levels: chefs and kitchen professionals, food and beverage service staff, housekeeping and front-office personnel, technicians and engineering staff, and, increasingly, workers who can combine hospitality skills with digital technology. "Hospitality often requires employees to work weekends, holidays and shifts, and many properties are located outside major urban centres, leading to a shortage of skilled manpower. There is also a perception among young workers that hospitality offers demanding working conditions without sufficiently attractive career progression," says Rajiv Mehra, general secretary, Federation of Associations in Indian Tourism & Hospitality (FAITH).

Healthcare faces a similar challenge, particularly in filling roles for nurses and allied health technicians who assist with procedures, equipment and physiotherapy. The shortage is especially acute for experienced OT nurses and technicians specialising in oncology, cardiac and emergency care. Mayank Rautela, group chief human resources officer at Apollo Hospitals, says one reason is the limited number of colleges offering relevant courses, compounded by a perception that compensation is unattractive. That may be true at the entry level, he acknowledges, but opportunities for career progression increase substantially with experience. To counter the misperception, Apollo has launched initiatives to make employees aware of career pathways from day one. Its programmes allow nurses to fast-track their careers. "Earlier, a staff nurse could be at the same position for five to seven years, but today we have created different bands—junior nurse, staff nurse, going all the



"The softer aspects of moving away from peers and family, staying in a different culture, eating different food are the part of the iceberg you can't see, and that needs to be looked into"

NITIN DAVE, *CEO, Quess Staffing*